Berkeley Police Department
Memorandum

To: City Manager Paul Buddenhagen Date: March 16, 2026

Deputy City Manager David White

From: Chief Jennifer Louis

Subject: **BPD Hiring/Staffing Levels and Staffing Level Impact Statements**

Purpose

This memorandum provides an overview of the Berkeley Police Department's current staffing levels, outlines the projected impacts of the City's 10% and 12.5% General Fund reduction scenarios, and explains the operational consequences that would result from implementation. This analysis reflects current staffing realities, anticipated attrition, recruitment constraints, and the operational risks associated with eliminating key sworn, dispatcher, and strategic positions necessary to sustain and modernize police operations.

Department-Wide Staffing Context

Prior to the FY25/26 budget adoption, the Department's authorized sworn staffing level was 181 positions; the current authorized level is 175. Of those, 154 sworn positions are filled, including ten officers in the academy and five in field training. The academy cohort includes two officers who began in October 2025 and are expected to graduate in May 2026, five who began in January 2026 and are projected to graduate in June/July 2026 (academy dependent), and three who started in February 2026 and are anticipated to graduate in August 2026. At the same time, approximately 22 sworn personnel are eligible for retirement by the end of calendar year 2026, including employees currently on workers' compensation leave. Routine separations and lateral transfers continue in an increasingly competitive regional hiring environment.

The Department is a personnel-driven organization, with approximately 93% of its General Fund budget allocated to personnel costs. As a result, meaningful reductions cannot be achieved through non-personnel savings alone. While limited non-personnel shifts and overtime reductions have been identified, they are insufficient to meet either the 10% or 12.5% reduction targets.

Staffing levels also directly impact overtime expenditures and employee wellness. The 2024 Citygate Workload and Organizational Study[1] recommended increasing Patrol staffing from 58 to 73 officers to meet workload demands and reduce overtime reliance. In FY25, minimum patrol staffing shortages alone accounted for nearly $3 million in overtime costs. Increased staffing would reduce reliance on overtime and allow officers to take leave and attend training without creating minimum staffing shortages.

The Department has also made significant financial and operational investments in current academy recruits, including background investigations, onboarding, academy tuition, equipment, and staff time dedicated to recruitment and training. Releasing recruits who are partially through the academy would forfeit these sunk costs, negatively impact morale, undermine recruitment efforts, and further delay efforts to stabilize staffing.

Hiring and Recruitment Impacts

The Department's staffing model depends on continuous hiring to offset an average annual attrition rate of approximately 9.23% over the past decade. At current staffing levels, this requires hiring approximately 14–16 officers annually simply to maintain existing sworn strength, before accounting for any reductions. The hiring process averages three to five months from application to conditional offer and must align with academy start dates throughout the year. For entry-level officers, the timeline from application to solo patrol deployment is approximately 18 months.

Because of this extended pipeline, maintaining open and funded positions to hire into is critical. Even short interruptions in hiring create compounding impacts: separations continue at an average rate of 9% annually while replacements take up to 18 months to become fully deployable. Experience from prior hiring freezes demonstrates that once the recruitment pipeline is disrupted, recovery can take multiple years. Even when funding is restored, competition from neighboring agencies significantly limits the Department's ability to rebuild staffing.

If hiring is frozen as part of budget implementation, routine retirements and separations will continue without replacement. With a sustained attrition rate near 9%, staffing would decline annually beyond modeled reduction levels, resulting in sworn staffing below those reflected in the 10% and 12.5% scenarios and further diminishing operational capacity and response readiness. A hiring freeze does not stabilize staffing; it accelerates its decline.

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Staffing Sustainability and Operational Risk

The Department is operating with minimal staffing buffers. Patrol and the Communications Center rely heavily on overtime to maintain minimum staffing levels, and routine absences for training, illness, injury, and leave already strain operations. When combined with an average 9% annual attrition rate, even modest reductions in hiring capacity compound quickly and reduce deployable staffing year over year.

The COVID-19 period created a sustained disruption to sworn staffing that the Department is still working to recover from. Beginning in 2020, retirements accelerated, hiring slowed, and competition for qualified applicants intensified. Between 2019 and 2022, sworn staffing declined from 169 to 148 officers (a reduction of more than 12 percent) while attrition continued at historically consistent levels. Because replacing a sworn officer requires approximately 18 months, losses compounded more quickly than they could be replaced.

This pattern mirrors national and regional trends in which staffing declines coincided with increased crime, slower response times, reduced proactive policing, and greater reliance on overtime. Once staffing falls below operational thresholds, recovery requires multiple consecutive years of sustained hiring and stable funding. Interruptions to hiring, particularly in the context of a 9% annual attrition rate, risk repeating the prolonged public safety impacts experienced during the post-COVID staffing crisis.

Further reductions or hiring interruptions would push the Department beyond a sustainable threshold. As staffing declines, specialty units must be consolidated or eliminated to preserve patrol response, resulting in reduced investigative capacity, diminished proactive enforcement, and slower response times. Without sustained hiring, staffing levels will continue to erode regardless of budget modeling, creating long-term impacts that may take years to reverse.

Communications Center

The Communications Center is currently staffed at 20 of 32 authorized positions and is responsible for answering emergency and non-emergency calls and dispatching police and fire resources. Operational capacity is constrained by the limited number of fully trained Public Safety Dispatcher II personnel, who are the only staff qualified to independently dispatch emergency calls. Over the past four years, the Center has experienced approximately a 67% attrition rate among new hires, with most separations occurring during training or within the first year of employment. As a result, the center relies on mandatory overtime to maintain

minimum staffing, and training capacity cannot be accelerated due to limited trainer availability. Continued hiring is essential to overcome the challenge of a low trainee passage rate, sustain safe staffing levels and prevent increased fatigue, burnout. Any further attrition that would directly affect call-handling and dispatch reliability.

Patrol and Specialty Units

Patrol remains the Department's core function and frontline response to calls for service. Additional reductions will likely require consolidation or elimination of specialty functions including Traffic/Motors, Community Services Bureau, the Bicycle Team, and significant portions of the Detective Bureau to preserve minimum patrol staffing.

Community Services Bureau

The Community Services Bureau serves as the Department's primary liaison for community engagement, problem-solving, special event coordination, and collaboration with City departments on complex quality-of-life issues. The unit plays a central role in addressing long-term community concerns and supporting the City's response to homelessness through sustained partnerships and relationship-based policing. Further reductions would significantly curtail outreach and coordinated response efforts, shifting complex community issues back to patrol units already operating with limited capacity.

Bike Team

The Bicycle Team provides focused patrol coverage in business districts and other high-priority areas while serving as one of the Department's most flexible deployment resources. The team supports warrant operations, special events, and patrol backfill, while maintaining a visible presence and problem-solving approach in commercial corridors such as Downtown and the South Campus area. Additional reductions would diminish crime reduction and community engagement efforts and remove a critical, flexible resource that helps stabilize operations during ongoing staffing shortages.

Traffic Bureau

The Traffic Bureau investigates serious and fatal collisions, conducts traffic enforcement, manages traffic safety grants, and provides data analysis to support roadway safety initiatives. Traffic officers possess specialized training required for complex collision investigations and are integral to Vision Zero initiatives, special event planning, and multi-department coordination on

roadway and encampment operations. Further reductions would shift these responsibilities to patrol, significantly limiting proactive traffic safety work and reducing overall response capacity.

Detective Bureau

The Detective Bureau conducts follow-up investigations on serious and complex crimes and manages digital evidence, forensic analysis, and case preparation. Reduction staffing has already required prioritization among critical cases and limited proactive investigative work, including cold case review and regional task force participation. Additional reductions would increase case backlogs, reduce investigative follow-up and victim support, and diminish the Department's ability to resolve crimes and maintain effective investigative operations.

Conclusion

The Department is operating at staffing levels with little margin for further reductions. Retirements and ongoing separations are making it increasingly difficult to sustain specialized units and maintain minimum service levels.

Any reduction in sworn or dispatcher positions must be weighed against the Department's capacity to deliver essential public safety services. Maintaining vacant positions to hire into is critical; without them, hiring and training delays will create lasting impacts on Berkeley's public safety infrastructure and risk replicating the post-COVID staffing crisis experienced by many agencies, where low staffing led to slower response times, reduced service capacity, and prolonged recovery.

The modeled 10% and 12.5% reduction scenarios require significant personnel eliminations that will materially reduce public safety service levels, particularly if hiring is frozen and historical attrition trends continue.

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Appendix A
Berkeley Police Department Sworn Attrition Data (2015–2026)

The table below summarizes annual sworn staffing levels, hiring gains, separations, net change, and attrition rates. Gains and losses are shown to illustrate the sustained hiring demand necessary to offset an average annual attrition rate of approximately 9.23%.

Year	Starting Sworn	Gains (Hires)	Losses (Separation)	Net Change	Ending Sworn	Attrition Rate
2015	167	14	15	-1	166	9.0%
2016	166	20	19	+1	167	11.4%
2017	167	16	24	-8	159	14.4%
2018	159	17	17	0	159	11.0%
2019	159	24	14	+10	169	8.8%
2020	169	8	16	-8	161	9.5%
2021	161	8	14	-6	155	8.7%
2022	155	11	18	-7	148	11.6%
2023	148	12	10	+2	150	6.8%
2024	150	12	18	-6	144	12.0%
2025	144	18	10	+8	152	6.9%
2026	152	3	1	+2	TBD	0.65%

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Appendix B

Technology Budget consideration by year – Total = presumed GF savings

Tech	FY27	FY28	FY29	FY30	4-Year Total
DFR	$150,000.00	$300,000.00	$300,000.00	$300,000.00*	**$1,050,000.00**
UAS**	$44,500.00	$-	$-	$44,500.00*	**$89,000.00**
ALPR	$165,000.00	$165,000.00	$165,000.00	$165,000.00	**$660,000.00**
Community Streams	$-	$-	$-	$-	**$-**
SCA***	$38,394.00	$38,394.00	$38,394.00	$38,394.00	**$153,576.00**
CA	$-	$185,000.00	$185,000.00	$185,000.00	**$555,000.00**
New Subtotal	$397,894.00	$688,394.00	$688,394.00	$732,894.00	**$2,507,576.00**
PTZ	$77,500.00	$77,500.00	$77,500.00	$77,500.00	**$310,000.00**
Tech Subtotal	$475,394.00	$765,894.00	$765,894.00	$810,394.00	**$2,817,576.00**
FTE (3 total)	$(864,753.00)	$(864,753.00)	$(864,753.00)	$(864,753.00)	**$(3,459,012.00)**
Total	**$(389,359.00)**	**$(98,859.00)**	**$(98,859.00)**	**$(54,359.00)**	**$(641,436.00)**

*Assumed (not quoted)
** to be paid for via BPD special funds
***This is the positional "roll up" from crime analyst to Senior Crime Analyst (proposed new classification, it is currently staffed by limited term PM1 rolled up from budgeted crime analyst position).

Note: Flock as offered 10% discount on new tech if executed in March 2026